

The missing layer between AI adoption and AI value

11 hours saved a week. 13% of organizations better off. **Where did the rest go?**



Two lenses, one system

Leaders and workers are
describing the same gap.

KPMG asked 2,145 senior leaders across
20 countries. The Work AI Index asked
6,000 digital workers across 3.

Leaders see deployment racing ahead
of proven ROI. Workers see 87%
adoption and 13% organizational gains.

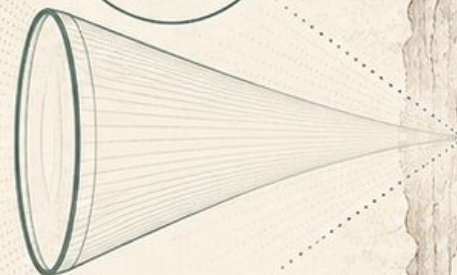


Different samples, so this
isn't a scorecard — it's
two instruments reading
one system.

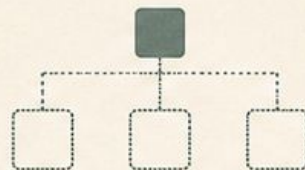
- ▶ A separate MIT study points the same
way from a third method.

LEADERS LENS

Senior leaders



Deployment is
racing ahead of
proven ROI.



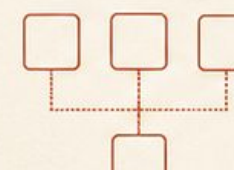
Top-down view of the system

WORKERS LENS

Digital workers



87% adoption and
13% organizational
gains.



Bottom-up view of the system

THE MISSING
LAYER

Where adoption and
value fail to connect.

Where the value leaks

The saved hours come back as botsitting.

Feeding context, checking outputs, debugging, rerunning prompts, cleaning up confident-but-wrong work. Workers spend 6.4 hours a week on this — more than they spend using AI. And 36% of AI sessions fail outright, needing a restart or substantial rework.



AI time isn't production time.

Much of it is supervision, repair, and judgment.

HOW AI TIME IS SPENT (WEEKLY)

37%



botsitting

36%



producing

27%



learning



VISIBLE RESULT

Polished output.
What gets seen.

HIDDEN LABOR

What doesn't get seen.



Feeding context
Gathering, formatting, and pasting.



Checking outputs
Verifying accuracy and completeness.



Debugging
Finding errors and inconsistencies.



Rerunning prompts
Iterating to get better results.



Cleanup
Fixing, editing, and reformatting.



Judgment
Deciding what to trust, what to change, what to escalate.

Not all of it is waste

The goal isn't zero supervision.

Verifying high-stakes outputs, refining prompts, adding context, deciding what not to trust — that's judgment work, and it's the point. The waste is when it stays invisible, unbudgeted, unsupported, unrewarded, and dumped downstream as cleanup.



When organizations don't design this work, workers absorb it.



Productive judgment

- ✓ Verifying high-stakes outputs
- ✓ Refining prompts and instructions
- ✓ Adding relevant context
- ✓ Deciding what not to trust

VS.



Avoidable cleanup

- ✗ Invisible work
- ✗ Unbudgeted work
- ✗ Unsupported work
- ✗ Downstream cleanup

The warning signs are gone

AI changes the signals reviewers use to catch weak work.

Rough drafts used to carry warning signs — awkward phrasing, visible gaps. AI smooths them away, so polish stops tracking substance. The ‘this looks off’ reflex stops firing when it should



Replace informal suspicion with **explicit evaluation** — quality bars, source checks, review rituals, ownership rules.



Judgment is the scarce capability

The best AI users aren't the heaviest. They're the **most discerning**.

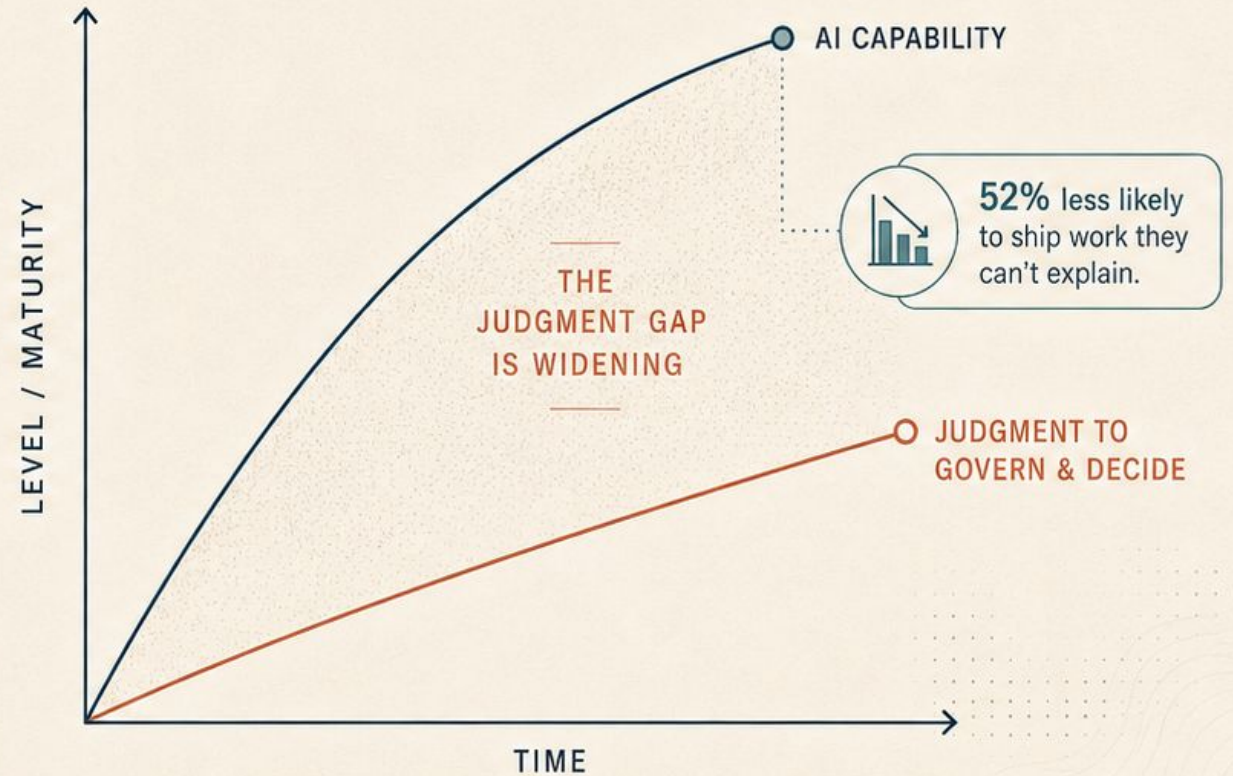
High performers keep their own judgment in the lead and treat AI as a tool, not an authority. In the data, they're **52% less likely** to ship work they can't explain.

Capability is spreading faster than the judgment to govern it.



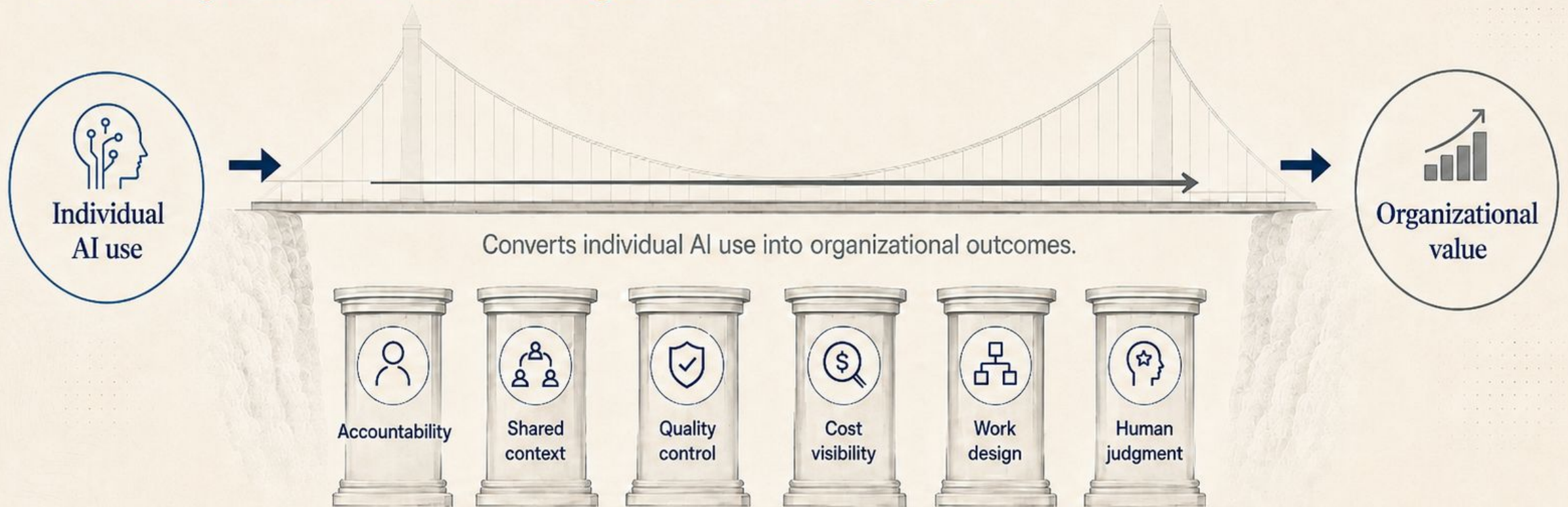
The scarce resource isn't access to AI. It's the judgment to use it well.

CAPABILITY IS OUTPACING JUDGMENT



The missing layer is infrastructure

Between individual AI use and organizational value sits a deliberate layer — and **the organizations that realize gains build it on purpose.**



Governance has to reach the work surface to matter.

The integration test.



Pick one real AI-assisted workflow — not the roadmap, one place a person actually uses AI.

Then ask:

- | | | |
|---|---|--|
| ☐ 1. Who owns the decision? | → |  ownership → accountability |
| ☐ 2. What does it cost to run? | → |  cost → cost visibility |
| ☐ 3. What context does it need? | → |  context → shared context |
| ☐ 4. What quality bar must it meet? | → |  quality → quality control |
| ☐ 5. Who can explain, challenge, or override the output? | → |  override → judgment |



These five questions are the operating architecture of AI value.



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Read the full post

The full five-question test and both reports, in one read.

at

barbhs.com →



barbhs.com + Sensemaking AI